locking resolution fields—hence the name "interlaced". The direct drawback of this method is that one cannot stop a frame and see a clear picture. Unlike in film, where you can freeze a frame and get a perfect still, the quality of interlaced scanned videos is somewhat inferior. Also, the screen motion when observed very closely exhibits a choppiness and lacks the smoothness and fluidity of film. This effect is especially noticeable in VHS tapes where the screen flickers when you hit the pause button. Most consumer camcorders record use interlaced scanning at 60i (60 frames per second with interlaced scanning) that is equal to 60 fields (lines of resolution) per second which, when interlaced, become 30 frames per second.

In progressive scanning, the two fields of resolution that make up each frame are recorded simultaneously. This produces smoother motion and prevents the flickering when you hit the Pause button. With progressive scanning, the quality begins to approach that of film. Camcorders are available at progressive scanning rates of both 30p and 24p (30 or 24 frames-per-second progressive scan) but this is usually achieved by a bit of hardware / software manipulation that alters and approximates a 60i scan. While this may not give you true film-like motion quality, the choppiness and flicker associated with interlaced scans is almost done away with. "True" 30p camcorders are also available, but they are invariably at the top end of the market.

1.2.13 Audio

Sound is tricky. At the lower end of camcorders, recorded audio can suffer from such things as motor noise, the sound of hands handling the camcorder, or even the breathing sounds of the cameraman! Front-mounted microphones are better at capturing the sound from the front of the camcorder, as against top-mounted ones. However, if audio quality is an important consideration in your shoot, look for camcorders that support external microphones (via a microphone jack) or an accessory shoe (a slot to connect optional accessories such as microphones or lights). Also look for a headphone jack. You can use the headphones to monitor the quality of the audio as it is being recorded. Some